data governance processes need to balance company-wide cohesion of data solutions, usually achieved through standardization, versus autonomy-driven flexibility and creativity offered to data product teams.

It is imperative to understand that there is no silver-bullet solution to balancing central governance and local autonomy! The approach will always depend on the specifics of your organization. For example, what are the needs and the maturity of your data product owners? What is the data-related risk appetite of the organization? What is the level of expertise of your central data governance team? How sensitive is the data you're working with? You need to answer these and other questions before you'll be able to set the responsibilities of central and local teams.

Another set of policies is required to ensure interoperability of data products and the ability of data consumers to join them together readily. Finally, the procedures need to provide the compatibility of various data products without explicitly enforcing an overarching data model. An approach such as this has been proved to create a bottleneck in data operations.

The data mesh tries to answer that need with federalization of data governance. *Federalization* in this context means having a governing structure operating at parity at distinct levels—central and local. The central level of governance, executed by the data governance council (of course, this governance body may use another name, e.g., in chapter 3 we call it simply the *data governance team*), will decide on a minimal set of global rules required to ensure safe and secure discoverability and interoperability of data products.

Data product teams, led by data product owners, are responsible for developing their products with a high degree of autonomy, deciding on all technical and procedural problems (within boundaries of the enterprise technology stack). There is no silver-bullet solution as to the precise division of responsibilities, the structure of the data governance council, and exact rules governing the data world. Instead, each business will have its own set of global rules, leaving domain teams with different levels of control over their data products. Chapter 4 discusses the effects of various levels of domain team autonomy on their agility and overall system complexity.